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EN3227 Romanticism
Dr. Susan Ang
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I declare that all material in this assignment is my own work and does not involve plagiarism. Furthermore, I have not used any secondary material in my analysis.

Signature:  Date: 11th November 2022

In writing the following essay, I have set out to:

1. Begin and conclude sections with appropriate signposting and use clear topic sentences for paragraphs
2. Construct a clear and concise thesis statement that follows the argument set out in the rest of the essay
3. Accurately identify and make arguments about formal characteristics of a poem (meter, rhyme)

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Met in Aspect:
Feminine in Romanticism

Women in Romantic poetry often embody contradictions that throw into question their 'true' appearance or intention. The Romantic woman's contradictions are best understood when we simply accept their complexity without trying to rationalise and imposing our assumptions onto them. I argue that the Romantic female is a figure of unreadability that cannot be interpreted, and this unreadability is displaced onto the narrative by her presence as well.

The following essay will first close-read Bryon's 'She Walks in Beauty' and draw a sketch of how the woman's beauty is perceived in the poem. This degree to which this mode of perceiving the feminine can be applied to the poetry of Coleridge and Keats will then be examined. This mode of perception will be expanded to include not only a sole female character, but also symbols aligned with the feminine through 'Rime of the Ancient Mariner' and 'Ode to Psyche'.

She Walks in Beauty

Byron's 'She Walks in Beauty' describes a woman's beauty as the achievement of a harmonious balance between two contradictory concepts, but I posit that this balance collapses in both the poem and its subject. In other words, I am arguing that the beauty of balance is eroded within the same poem that lauds it.

'She Walks in Beauty' deals in binaries, both conceptually and mathematically. In the first stanza, we see two diametrically opposed concepts of a binary come together: the woman is likened to a clear, starry night, beautiful because she embodies the "best of dark and bright", eliciting a "tender light" more muted than what we would see during the day. The contrasting day and night meld into one another in her appearance, and the second stanza refines this merging to a delicate and precise balance: just "one shade the more [or] one ray the less" would

destroy half her beauty. The potential loss of beauty will be precise too, since it will tip over the careful balance and reduce the woman to one half of the binary – another degree of 'darkness' will take away her 'brightness', leaving her only beautiful in terms of 'darkness'.

This proposed precise loss of her balanced beauty will only serve to sharpen the opposites it brings together; further, even though this loss is hypothetical, its detailing divides our perception of the beauty's embodiment. The following lines tell us there must be a precision in the assigning of the balance-beauty, too:

> One shade the more, one ray the less, 7
> Had half impaired the nameless grace 8
> Which waves in every raven tress, 9
> Or softly lightens o'er her face; 10

The balance between the contrast of her black hair over her (presumably) fair skin is complicated by the "Or" that opens line 10. Here, "or" could be have been easily replaced by the word 'and', but in its deliberateness, it gives us a choice to select where the harmonious beauty lies. She cannot entirely embody the contradiction: the harmony of the beauty is undone in its separation of the woman's hair and face, reducing them and making them exclusive to one another. The threatened loss of balance described in lines 7 and 8 is, in this sense, displaced onto the *site* of balance – she is granted harmonious beauty, but it can only exist in part of her.

The poem's form also reflects an asymmetry between balance and the woman's beauty. The poem is a lyric: aural harmony is built into its genre, and indeed, the contradictory concepts also achieve an aural harmony in the poem. The poem hinges, of course, on the rhyme of 'night' with both 'bright' and 'light', but in stanza two, the aurality pushes past the rhyme. We see an assonance in 'ray' and 'shade', 'ray' also invokes 'raven' in the following line, and there is a consonance in the stressed 'v' in 'waves', 'every', and 'raven'. However, this aural harmony of the poem is at odds with the division of the woman's features that takes place in line 10: the balance disintegrates between form and subject.

Similarly, this asymmetry manifests in stanza one: the perfect merging of day and night is not matched in its oral form. The use of iambic tetrameter fits itself to the rhythm of walking, like our muse's actions. However, the meter is inconsistent, and there are stutters in it: the iamb

is reversed into a trochee in line 4, emphasizing the word “meet”. The stress on “bright” is immediately followed by the stress on “meet”, forcing us to quicken the pace to *meet* the meter – the achievement of harmonious balance of dark and bright on paper actually trips us up in orality. The assonance in the ‘d’ sound in “gaudy day denies” at the close of the stanza is a repeated stress, and emphasizes this distance between the harmony of beauty occurring within the women and the harmony of the poem we are reading.

The last stanza is where the balance of the beauty itself also deviates: when it comes to the individuality or inner thoughts of his muse, there is no contradiction. There is a contrast between the “mind” and “all below” in line 17, they are two separate entities that are already “at peace” with each other. The expression of their proposed harmony, on the other hand, skews the dark/bright binary: she is said to spend her days doing good, her mind is peaceful and her heart is innocent, the ‘light’ superimposes itself onto moral goodness. This assumed virtuousness is represented in her physicality the features of the woman’s face are winning and glowing, they solely belong to the ‘light’ part of our pair. Noticeably, the facial features described in the last stanza exclude her eyes, that have already been asserted as where the “dark and bright / meet”. The disjunct “or” from line 10 lurks here, but the choice has been made for us: the perfect beauty and “nameless grace” is in her eyes only, not the rest of her face.

This dissolution of the harmonious contradiction is also visible in the rhymes Byron uses in the concluding stanza. ‘Eloquent’ and ‘innocent’ have two stressed syllables each, unlike the rest of the poem’s rhymes, making the iamb in their connecting rhyme ‘spent’ seem out of place. The balance of the poem, too, is lost as the woman is simplified.

However, the lyric’s concluding simplicity is suspicious for a poem and a poet that deal with the combination of contrasts; on the flip side, it is possible to read the poem’s subject as something other than a woman Byron saw walking. It is, for me, difficult to not imagine in the place of the woman Byron is talking about a more static image, one that can hold the fragile balance of his beauty – a figure more suited to the Louvre. The sculpted Nike of Samothrace or, perhaps more aptly where the Romantics are concerned, Delacroix’s painting Liberty Leading the People seem to invoke to me the beauty Byron talks about.





Figure 1. Unknown. The Winged Victory of Samothrace. 190 B.C, Louvre Museum, Paris.

Figure 2. Delacroix, Eugène. Liberty Leading the People. 1830, Louvre Museum, Paris.

These artworks can embody the beauty of balance that the poem cannot. Both women – goddesses – are depicted with one foot in front of them, walking like Byron's muse. They are a balance of dark and bright: the Winged Victory is imagined to be alighting on the deck of a ship during a storm, fighting against the wind, rain and lightning to either condemn the sailors to death, or grant the seamen safe passage. Liberty marches with the revolutionaries to independence, the French flag in one hand and a rifle in the other, her pedestal is a mound of dead bodies. Though depicted in motion, both figures have been captured in the moment of perfect balance between dark and bright, and this balance can never be lost due to the very nature of its preservation: in unchanging stone and paint.

In a sense, this interpretation justifies the virtuous qualities Bryon assigns to his muse: the ideals that the goddesses stand for remain unchanging, despite their otherworldly appearance. This beauty can only be perfectly balanced *within* stasis, hence "she walks *in* beauty" (italics mine) rather than 'beautifully', and "like the night", a blank portrait onto which she is painted. The woman herself really *does* nothing, except walk, the rest is done for us in her appearance only – aspect here adheres itself to its etymological origin of 'appearance' rather than its meaning of attribute or characteristic. The poem's concept of beauty as balance thus shies away

from the dynamism of a woman's inner life, since it is threatened by it: by definition, a balance is upended by any intensity, vibrancy or spontaneity – it is only sustained in stasis.

Byron captures only part of the allure of women in Romantic tradition in his lyric. Women are often figures of ambiguity, as I will discuss later, who embody contradictions, and their appearances, indeed, are both "dark and bright". However, unlike Bryon's muse whose beauty is precise and is merely threatened with the possibility of being pulled to one end of the binary, women in Romantic tradition can and are pulled to either side of a given binary within the same text: they pendulum between two interpretations, and there is rarely a resolution to this conflicting description of women – they simply are and are not at the same time. The constant shifting between two aspects and two readings renders them unknowable, they have no clarity and their ambiguity must simply be embraced. To emphasize the difference between Byron's woman and other Romantic women, I will use the example of another female figure that, like Bryon's muse, plays with the dark and bright in the next section – but, unlike Byron's woman, her ambiguity and contradiction is fleeting, spontaneous and unresolved.

Rime of the Ancient Mariner

The male/female binary can be mapped onto the balance/imbalance binary through Nietzche's theory of the Dionysian as opposed to the Apollonian. The Apollonian is male, and stands for light, clarity, structure and rationality; in contrast, the female Dionysian is irrational, passionate, unorganized, and ambiguous. We can see the Apollonian lean in Byron's mathematical precision of the woman's beauty in 'She Walks in Beauty'.

The feminine in Coleridge's Rime of the Ancient Mariner is squarely Dionysian in her manifestation. The instances of femininity within poem are often in reference to ships and the moon, both of which in themselves are Dionysian symbols of instability and uncertainty: the ship being thing that takes us away from land and civilization into the unknown sea, and the moon, of course, invokes 'lunar' and 'lunacy', the time when madness occurs. In this section, I will close-read these two symbols in Part III along with the introduction of Life-in-Death, one of the more prominent female figures in the text.

Life-in-Death's introduction to us is conflicting and unsettling. The Mariner's vessel is stranded, unmoving in the middle of the ocean, and the sailors are thirsty and starved. Life-in-

Death's ship approaches at this time of peril, causing the Mariner to feel hope at a possible rescue – he bites his own arm to wet his throat with blood in order to alert his crewmates, who "for joy did grin", sharing the Mariner's hopeful sight at the ship. However, the ship's approach signals to us something odd too: the Mariner's ship cannot move due to the lack of wind, but this ship approaches "without a breeze, without a tide". The ship blocks the setting sun with its masts, "as if through a dungeon-grate," leaving us an unsettling image of a ship imprisoning the sun. The rationality and hope the Apollonian symbolizes is blocked with it. Despite this haunting imagery, there is still a beauty in the ship: her sails reflect the dusky light, "like restless gossameres", adding a softness to it. But in the following stanza we see that the light has also exposed the ship's structure, which resembles that of a human skeleton with ribs, a sudden and frightening intrusion into the vision of hope. This changes our perception of the imprisoned sun, now restrained by the ship's ribs as it climbs the horizon rather than its masts, and gossamers, which now take on a ghastly appearance, no longer silks shining in the sun, but rather translucent skin peeling off a skeleton.

This unsettling feeling persists in the introduction of the nightmarish Life-in-Death. Her very title is an inexplicable contradiction: the binary of life and death is brought together in her name. She is almost mistaken for her companion Death ("are there two?" asks the Mariner), implying a certain supernatural or menacing quality about her. The Mariner then, somehow, intuitively recognises her when he sees at her and takes in her appearance:

Her lips were red, her looks were free, 190

Her locks were yellow as gold: 191

Her skin was as white as leprosy, 192

The Night-mare LIFE-IN-DEATH was she, 193

Who thicks man's blood with cold. 194

Despite her association with the ghostly ship and Death, there is a conventional attractive about her too: she has red lips, blond hair and pale skin. But these features could be deadly as well as beautiful. The red lips suggest an unnatural bloodiness in contrast to her almost-bloodless skin, the paleness of which is attributed to disease, as opposed to Byron's glowing skin that

represents virtuousness. Her "free" looks have erotic implications, but they also imply a wildness in her manner. She is said to thicken the blood of men, which implies a kind of warmth, but this thickening is actually "with cold". All these elements make her into a series of contradictions

Life-in-Death's contrast to the Byronic woman is clear in the next stanza. She is playing a game of dice against Death, which she wins, and then whistles thrice. The whistling seems to be a celebration of her victory, but at the same moment, the setting sun disappears entirely, and the sky becomes a starry night. Unlike Byron's woman, who is likened to the starry night whose light the day denies, Life-in-Death shifts the skies to her will. The action of walking that Bryon's woman did is now that of the cosmic, as the darkness comes "at one stride" and the stars "rush out".

Her power is both awesome and frightening, yet in the text the motivation for this demonstration is difficult to read. Life-in-Death's last action in the poem is her whistling, after which the Mariner's strife continues as his entire crew drops dead, and he finds he cannot pray. Some interpretations of the poem assume that Life-in-Death laid this curse on the Mariner as she has won the Mariner's soul in her game with Death, according to the marginal gloss. However, both the subsequent marginal gloss and narrative events complicate this reading: it is only "at the rising of the moon" (marginal gloss, line 203) when the it "clomb above the eastern bar" (line 209) that the *sailors* turn to curse the Mariner. Life-in-Death was only responsible for the disappearance of the sun and the appearance of the stars: the moon comes after a period of time. The Moon is a symbol of the Dionysian and brings with it irrational thought, especially in Romantic tradition[1]. If it is difficult to say that Life-in-Death cursed the Mariner, we are forced to accept a more Dionysian one: that we must simply embrace the ambiguity.

Despite her fleeting presence in the poem's text, Life-in-Death's character is visibly complex and problematizes a straightforward understanding of the text. Moreover, her ambiguity is heightened by feminine-aligned symbols like the ship and the moon – these symbols layer each other and make themselves contradictory. Through Keats' symbolically rife writing in the next section, I will demonstrate how the female and the mode of perceiving her is made opaque through narrative structure.

[1] I am referring to Wordsworth's 'Strange Fits of Passion'.

Ode to Psyche

The Ode has a structure well-suited to exposing the complexity of a binary. It lays out an argument in its first phase, taking a turn or 'strophe' to one side of a debate; often, the Romantics take this strophe to its limit before entering into the second phase, the counterturn or 'antistrophe'. The antistrophe argues the opposing side to the initial argument, breaking it down and presenting it in a new light. Finally, the ode concludes with a stand or 'epode' between the two turns, reconciling the two opposing binaries.

Keats further complicates this odic structure in 'Ode to Psyche'. In the first sentence itself, he apologizes to psyche for singing her secrets, the ode usually being a public performance, but he is, in fact, singing it into her own ear. The strophe is hence framed by this intimacy as it delves into the image of Psyche and her lover, Eros, in a forest. This image is infused with the Dionysian: the narrator is in a state of altered consciousness, "wander[ing] in a forest thoughtlessly" unable to trust his eyes. The whispering trees and hidden brook emphasize the secrecy of the location, eliciting an air of transgression. Though the two are sleeping, their positions are erotic in their intimacy – indeed, they seem to have been separated only "by soft-handed slumber". The feminine unreadability operates here, subtly, too: the narrator wonders if he saw "Psyche with awaken'd eyes," and later, easily identifies the male lover Eros, but once again questions Psyche's identity.

However, the antistrophe brings into question this her mysterious allure: she is unrecognized and unworshipped by people. However, the terms of the worship Psyche deserves that Keats outlines are strikingly unholy as well: there is an eroticism in "nor virgin-choir to make delicious moan / upon midnight hours", and "no pipe, no incense sweet / from chain-swung censer teeming" implies an intoxication of drugs. The mode of her worship is tinged with sin, ritualistic and almost cult-like in its metrical chanting.

The epode comes about with Keats the narrator declaring that he will construct a temple for her in his mind using his imagination, but this conclusion leads us back to the strophe. He repeats the terms of worship he laid down earlier, but the power of his imagination is clear: the "nor" of the previous stanza is replaced with "let me be thy choir … thy pipe, thy incense sweet" and so on. He goes on to say he will build a temple for her in his mind, which has a garden with

dense trees and flowers, a “wide quietness” that elicits the “whisp’ring roof of leaves” from stanza one.

The image of the strophe is now re-visioned by us, seen in a new light, but no more clear. The “ tender eye-dawn” becomes the eye, or ‘I’, of Keats who gives light that allows us to view the sight of the lovers. He constructs Nature, The fact that this is his imagination also further complicates the hesitant recognition of Psyche: even as a construct of his mind, she is difficult to pin down. The intimacy of the scene is sharpened because the already-hidden forest situates itself in the “untrodden region” of Keats’ mind, but then the transgressiveness of the narrator’s obtrusion onto the scene is questioned: how can he violate his own imagination?

The looping narrative of ‘Ode to Psyche’ certainly creates a series of contradictions. The ‘reality’ of the poem is, of course, completely impossible given that it declares itself to be a figment of the imagination. Psyche is unreadable in the sense that despite being a creation of the narrator, he himself cannot recognise her. The chaotic Dionysian is what paradoxically structures the text: we can accept that this poem resists rationality and its meaning cannot be unravelled precisely because it was imaginatively constructed.

Conclusion

The complexity of a Romantic woman is attributed to her ability to embody contradiction and bring together binaries such of “dark and bright”. Byron’s woman is different from Coleridge’s Life-in-Death and Keats’ Psyche because the narrative shifts from simply perceiving her from the outside her to imposing our own judgements onto her inner life. The Romantic woman and by extent, the feminine, complicates the narrative because her perceived appearance is always contradictory. The only redemption of the narrative she polarizes is to meet her in aspect not assumption, and simply embrace the contradiction of her character.

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Evaluation of Goals:

1. I believe that the individual paragraphs have mostly appropriate topic sentences; however the flow of ideas between sections seems stilted
2. The main thesis loses some traction in the close-readings of the poems, though I attempt to link concluding paragraphs for each poem to the thesis. The final conclusion could have done a more comprehensive job at restating the thesis, now evidenced
3. I still find it difficult to confidently say that I have identified the meter in the Byron section: it sounds correct to my ear, but I am unsure if that means it is actually correct.